Lesson 16

THE CHURCH

Aim: *To share the Biblical concept of the church.*

Intro:

What is a church? This question has several connotations to different kinds of Christians. These varied ideas sometimes bring confusion and division to many believers.

Yet God's will is for His people to be united. In this study, we will try to discover what the Bible says about the church.

I. BIBLICAL MEANING OF THE WORD " CHURCH"

Greek word - *"Ecclesia"*, meaning an assembly or gathering of called out ones. It is a compound word.

"Ek" which means "*out from"; "kaleo"* which means *"to call"*. This definition implies, therefore, that the church is NOT A BUILDING, but people, called out from the Kingdom of darkness to the kingdom of light".

1 Peter 2: 9 *"But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, God's special possession, that you may declare the praises of him who called you out of darkness into his wonderful light."*

John 4:23 *"Yet a time is coming and has now come when the true worshipers will worship the Father in the Spirit and in truth, for they are the kind of worshipers the Father seeks.*

II. TWO CONCEPTS OF CHURCH

A. **Local church -** a body of Christians in a city or locality hence the name local church.

B. **Universal church -** the whole body of believers on earth regardless of organization or denomination as long as it recognizes Jesus as Lord and Saviour.

III. THE FOUNDER OF THE CHURCH

Matthew 16:18 "And I tell you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of Hades will not overcome it. "

1. **Jesus Christ -** Matthew 16:1 Gk. *"Petra"* means " huge rock" Gl. *"petros"* means " small rock"

1 Peter 2:6-8 "For in Scripture it says: "See, I lay a stone in Zion, a chosen and precious cornerstone, and the one who trusts in him will never be put to shame." 7 Now to you who believe, this stone is precious. But to those who do not believe, "The stone the builders rejected has become the capstone," 8 and, "A stone that causes men to stumble and a rock that makes them fall." They stumble because they disobey the message-which is also what they were destined for. "

2. **Jerusalem -** Acts 1:8

"*But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes on you; and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth."*

IV. ILLUSTRATION OF THE CHURCH

A. Body of Christ - Ephesians 1:22,23

“22 And God placed all things under his feet and appointed him to be head over everything for the church, 23 which is his body, the fullness of him who fills everything in every way.”

B. The temple of God - 1 Peter 2:5-6

“you also, like living stones, are being built into a spiritual house[a] to be a holy priesthood, offering spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ. 6 For in Scripture it says:

“See, I lay a stone in Zion, a chosen and precious cornerstone, and the one who trusts in him will never be put to shame.”

C. The bride of Christ - Ephesians 5: 25-27

25 “Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for

her 26 to make her holy, cleansing[a] her by the washing with water through the word, 27 and to present her to himself as a radiant church, without stain or wrinkle or any other blemish, but holy and blameless.”

CONCLUSION

The church is not a building nor denomination, but a body of believers regardless of affiliation. We must, therefore, see the church from God's perspective so we can love all born again Christians and accept them in spite of their denominational background, for God wants us to become one.

John 17: 20-23

“20 “My prayer is not for them alone. I pray also for those who will believe in me through their message, 21 that all of them may be one, Father, just as you are in me and I am in you. May they also be in us so that the world may believe that you have sent me. 22 I have given them the glory that you gave me, that they may be one as we are one— 23 I in them and you in me—so that they may be brought to complete unity. Then the world will know that you sent me and have loved them even as you have loved me.